

Improvement vs innovation

In the course of speaking to readers, arguing with other team Digit members, and friends, I'm a little tired of the way we all tend to over-use words and phrases such as "innovation", "out of the box", "pioneers" etc. If anything, we need someone to innovate and come up with a new word. Apple came up with a pretty catchy one... The new iPad is advertised as "Resolutionary", because of the "Retina Display" it features.

It's a great display (built by Samsung), with a resolution of 2048 x 1536 – that's double the size of the older model's 1024 x 768 screen (or 4 times the area). Games and apps will eventually look amazing, but it will take some time for app makers to catch up. In fact, there were initial complaints about the Apple-limited 3G download size (20 MB) for Apps (later increased to 50 MB), since developers needed to double the resolution of images included in their apps for the new screen. Some early adopters also complained about the device getting too hot with prolonged use... but we'll reserve our judgments for when we review it ourselves.

Anyway, I didn't bring that up to bash Apple, because I'm sure it will eventually turn out to be a great device, once developers learn to exploit the potential of all that's new.

However, I did bring it up to illustrate the point that, much like our desktop and laptop screens, tablet screens were bound to increase pixel density and quality – that's exactly why display manufacturers spend billions on R&D. There's a difference between the simple improvement of technology and innovation.

I'm not trying to say that fitting 3.1 million pixels into a 9.7-inch screen was not tremendously hard work for Samsung, because it obviously was. Rumours have it that LG and Sharp were also in the running, but failed to deliver a suitable display. Apple's designers have also probably spent inordinate amounts of time to fit in a much more powerful battery in almost the same volume of space.

However, forgive me for sounding a little jaded, but that's not real innovation. Steve Jobs' undivided insistence for usability and sleekness of products was

innovative. In fact you could perhaps use all the superlatives you like, because the results he achieved are phenomenal.

Technology innovation is not just being stymied at a product level, actually, it's more a case of it happening at the company level as well. A recent article in Inc., titled "Have Tech Start-ups Lost Their Sense of Fun?" speaks about this worrying trend. People somehow have forgotten to try and make something innovative, crazy, and tremendously fun. Instead, it's all about becoming a huge success. "There was a time when people building things on the Internet didn't have a dream to be one of the biggest companies out there; their goal was not to be the next General Motors," writes Erik Sherman in the article.

Actually, that's exactly what big companies such as Microsoft, Google, Facebook and Apple have going against them – they're too big to try out things, or take the silly yet fun route. Yes, even Google, despite having "Innovation Time Off" 20 per cent of the time! Smaller companies, or startups have the liberty to try new things, but don't necessarily do so. It can't always be fun and games, of course, but crazy innovators could certainly do with a wider berth.

Instead of being allowed to go wild with code, or try out innovative features, developers these days seem to focus more on enticing you to part with as much user data as possible – as we discussed in last month's cover story, your data is a gold mine to everyone running an online business these days.

Even the adult industry seems to have gone cold – surprising, because they used to be amongst the most innovative businesses at one time. HD-DVD died, because they chose Blu-ray. In fact, we owe a lot to them – streaming videos, web cam chatting, online payment gateways, broadband, online networking... all driven by the need to access the forbidden. However over the past few years, nothing! Actually there are reports of new "sensing" technologies being experimented with... but this is neither the place nor the time...

Team Digit has also argued often about whether there ever will be another



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garage startup to make it big. Many are of the opinion that any new and innovative service or product would just be assimilated into one of the bigger names via buyouts, takeovers or by patent lawsuits. I certainly hope not, because I would love to write about Indian companies or entrepreneurs that believe otherwise, and make a real mark for themselves by being truly innovative; and hey, even if your idea doesn't make you a Zuckerberg, there's nothing really wrong with going the Sabeer Bhatia way, is there?

Write in to us, if you're are doing something truly innovative, or even if you just have an idea, and we'd be happy to give you feedback, feature you in Digit, and help any way we can. 

A handwritten signature in dark ink, appearing to read 'Robert Sovereign-Smith'.

Liked or hated this column?
Write in to editor@thinkdigit.com and let me know your thoughts.